

WRITING RÉSUMÉS

NETWORKING

Guide to Getting a Job

INTERVIEWING

SELLING YOURSELF



**Harvard
Business
Review**

Need a new job? Whether you've been laid off or are considering a job change, you need to search efficiently and effectively. Don't lurch from one job to the next. Use this guide to ensure that your next move is a carefully considered one. Learn how to:

- **Build a network to expand your contacts and identify career opportunities**
- **Prepare cover letters and résumés that will attract hiring managers' attention**
- **Develop your personal pitch—one compelling sentence about who you are and what you can do**
- **Shine in an interview**

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Need to Find a Job? Stop Looking So Hard

Finding a new job is all about relationships. So spend just an hour a day on job boards—and the rest of your time with interesting people doing things you love.

by Peter Bregman

CEO of Bregman Partners, a global leadership development and change management firm.

Read more by Bregman at blogs.hbr.org/bregman

QUICK READ

What's the most effective way to find a job?

- Devote only 1–2 hours a day to your job search.
- Spend the remaining time doing things you love. If possible, take a leadership role.
- People will notice your commitment, passion, and skill and will either hire you or help you get hired.

Do you know anyone who was dying to be in a relationship? Dated all the time, but never met the right person? Then, after accepting that he would be alone, he started focusing on other things and, lo and behold, met someone and got married?

How about someone who lost her job? Maybe she spent the next year working on her résumé, perusing job sites, devoting all her energy to getting work. All to no avail. Then, after she decided to stop looking so hard, out of the blue came a great job offer?

What is that? A karmic journey? A miracle? Statistical aberration? Perhaps it never really happens; perhaps we remember those stories precisely because they are so unusual.

Or, perhaps, it's a really great strategy.

Not a Lot of Jobs Out There

I just heard a story from a friend of mine. She knows a guy who's been out of a job for over a year. He spent the year working on his résumé and sending it out. He's on Internet job sites every day. He tries to meet with people when he has the opportunity, but there aren't a lot of opportunities these days. And he's getting more and more depressed. It's hard to get out of bed, but he does. He puts on a suit and tie, sits at his computer, and looks. Eventually, he figures, he'll find a job. I'm sure he's right.

A Counterintuitive Approach to Finding a Job

I do think there's another way to go through these times with less pain and more success. A way to increase your chances of getting that job. And maybe even enjoying it.

And here's my advice: **Give up. Not completely. But mostly. Stop trying so hard. At most, spend 1-2 hours a day on it.**

Rules for More Effective Job Hunting

Here are three important ways you can pare down the time you spend searching for a job:

- **Write your résumé quickly and efficiently.** Get the basic point across, and then let it go. It's the same with a cover letter. Your résumé is not going to get you a job.
- **Don't spend time on job sites.** With all the people who are looking, it's highly unlikely that someone will hire someone he or she doesn't already know (or hire someone that an associate doesn't already know).
- **Spend all your hunting time with people.** When you are job hunting, do it at lunch, on the phone, or by going for walks. Finding a job or new clients is all about human relationships.
- **Make a list of all the things you love doing or things that intrigue you that you'd like to try.** This is brainstorming, so don't limit the list or judge it; write down everything you can think of.
- **Separate the activities you do with people from the activities you do alone.** For example, gardening, reading, meditating, and writing are solitary activities. Volunteering to run a fund-raiser is with people.
- **Look at the activities you do alone,**

If you're only going to spend 1-2 hours a day on this, what should you do with your other 12 hours? If you aren't going to spend your days looking for work, how will you find it?

Being unemployed can easily leave a person feeling isolated. So, the first thing you should do is look at how you can increase your interaction with others.

What people are saying on hbr.org

"You did not mention the importance of networking for information with people you know who can connect you to people they know. Please do not think job searching/networking is an isolated process, because it [is] about developing relationships with others who will help you by giving you advice, giving you information about companies...or how you can position yourself better if you want to shift or change careers." —posted by Jayne

"The real pearl of wisdom you are offering is the aspect of volunteering. I would argue that those hours are "opportunity hours" for strategic networking. If the current research is sound, 80+% of new positions are found through the art of networking. Online and in-person. So yes, cover the basics in an hour, but volunteer for the other seven." —posted by Paul

"This could be an opportune time for those who have been disconnected or disenfranchised from what their passion is and the nature of their work to get aligned. It will make the job search more focused and create a greater sense of possibility." —posted by Jamie

"As you suggest, it's about a targeted and focused approach, with a broader perspective on needing to continue to cultivate, explore, and develop ourselves alongside the search." —posted by Andrew

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and figure out if you can (and want to) do them in a way that includes other people. For example, join a garden club or a reading or meditation group. Write something that other people read (a blog counts). If you can (and want to) make them activities that include other people, keep them on the list. If not, then cross them off the list.

- Here comes the fun part: **Spend 90% of your time doing things you love with other people who also love doing those things. If possible, take a leadership role.**

Examples of How to Spend Your Time

A good friend of mine has recently gotten involved in a church she adores. She loves all the pastors; she came to our house for dinner the other day and couldn't stop talking about them. So she met with them and offered to help in whatever way they needed. She's now leading a monthly strategy breakfast with the pastors and lay leaders of the church. I've never seen her so excited.

Another friend is training for a triathlon with a group of 15 others. He's in the best shape of his life and can't stop talking about it.

Why Does This Work?

Nobody wants to hire someone who needs to be hired to survive. Depressed is unattractive. People want to hire energized people who are passionate and excited about what they're doing. Jobs come from being engaged in the world and building human connections.

And there's an even more subtle reason. If you're passionate about what you're doing, and you're doing it with other people who are passionate about what they're doing, then chances are the work you eventually find will be more in line with the stuff you love to do. And then...then your life will change (not to be too dramatic, but it's true). No longer are you going after just anything that's out there. You're using this crisis as an opportunity to do the work you love, the work at which you excel and with people you enjoy. You can't help but succeed.

How to Manage Your Fear of Unemployment

Now, I know what you're thinking. You're

thinking, "That's a fine strategy if you're independently wealthy, getting that nice, fat trust fund check every week to pay for your gym membership (or mortgage or kid's tuition)." But what about the rest of us? Our inability to pay the monthly bills might actually intrude on our ability to enjoy unemployment. I know how scary it is to be without an income.

This fear is what you have to manage, because here's the kicker: **It won't take longer to find a job even though you're spending less time looking. It'll take you less time.** Pursuing things you love with people you enjoy will better position you to get a job; other people will notice your commitment, passion, skill, and personality and will either want to hire you or help you get hired.

Also, actively pursuing other activities while looking for a job will make you more qualified for a job—because you'll end up a more interesting person. When you finally get that job interview, you'll be able to recount the many things you've been doing (and will probably have a good time relating them) instead of saying that the only thing you've been doing for the past three years is looking (unsuccessfully, so far) for a job.

And even if it took the same amount of time to find a job, wouldn't you rather spend your time doing things that are interesting, with people you enjoy?

Don't waste this time. Do your job search. But do it in a way that excites you—a way that teaches you new things. A way that introduces you to new people who see you at your natural, most excited, most powerful best. Use and develop your strengths. The things at which you excel. The things you love.

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CONVERSATION STARTER

How to Make Your Network Work for You

by Ariana Green

Ariana Green is an award-winning journalist whose writing appears in the New York Times, the Guardian, Popular Science, TNR.com, Good magazine, and other publications. A former Fulbright and Gates scholar, she has master's degrees in journalism and political science and has studied at Brown and Cambridge universities.

For more on networking, visit blogs.hbr.org

Many people turn to networking when they're looking for a job, but the best time to build your network is *before* you need something, and the best time to keep that network strong is always. But what is the best way to do that? Simply collecting business cards and attending events may expand your number of contacts, but that does not increase the likelihood that those contacts will help you in the future. To reap the benefits of networking, you must know how to make your network work for you, and how you can work for your network.

Help Others First

The most universally agreed-upon networking tip is this: Offer to help others first, and they will return the favor. "You should always ask new contacts to tell you about a business challenge they are confronting," says Dr. Ivan Misner, PhD, lead author of *Networking Like a Pro: Turning Contacts into Connections*, and chairman of global networking organization BNI International. "That way, you might know someone who can help, and that's the start of a relationship."

Build Credibility

Misner teaches his clients to focus on gaining credibility, which grows, he says, when they keep appointments, act on promises, verify facts, and render services. "Failure to live up to expectations—to keep both explicit and implicit promises—can kill a budding relationship before it breaks through the ground," he warns.

Networking well makes for a brighter future, so Misner advises people to think beyond a current need. “People tend to forget about the importance of long-term credibility because they’re so focused on making an immediate sale,” Misner says. “But with that approach, you only eat what you kill that day.” Focus on becoming known and trusted instead; a long-lasting relationship is more beneficial to both parties.

Lillian Bjorseth, author of *Breakthrough Networking: Building Relationships That Last*, reminds her clients to share information. “One of my favorite follow-up methods is to send someone a relevant article, photo, anecdote, marketing tip, or other resource via e-mail,” she says. Follow-through on seemingly unimportant promises or casual conversations can be just as integral to business success as delivering a reliable product.

Make Sure People Know You

It’s not enough to be an expert on something if nobody knows you well enough to think about calling you. Creating an inviting image for yourself can generate business and opportunities. “Our research shows that people are much more likely to call if someone is not just an expert but also has initiated some sort of social exchange to make others comfortable,” says Noshir Contractor, professor of behavioral sciences at Northwestern University’s Kellogg School of Management, who has done research on social and knowledge networks.

While Facebook, LinkedIn, Twitter, and other online networking sites can become time drains, online networking is useful for strengthening connections. By posting Facebook or Twitter links to relevant articles, you can provide value to your virtual friends and show your engagement with pertinent business issues. Writing original articles or posting commentary keeps you on other people’s minds and enables them to see how involved you are in your industry. It is an efficient way to continue a relationship with those you know.

But online communication is not enough, especially for newer contacts. The true benefit is that it often leads to in-person contact because people feel more comfortable initiating a meeting with someone they “know” electronically. It’s especially important to seek

and accept face-to-face meetings with newer contacts, because technology can never match a human connection. In-person check-ins are also useful for contacts you already know, but given people’s busy schedules, it’s most pressing to push for personal meetings with contacts you haven’t spent much time with outside of a group gathering.

Think About How People Feel

Understanding psychology—your own and other people’s—should factor into your strategy. “Some people are really busy and harried, or they’re not quite as affable,” says psychologist James Waldroop, an author and CEO of Career Leader, an Internet-based career assessment used by corporations and business programs worldwide. “The point is to read your audience and know to contact some people less frequently.”

But, Waldroop points out, even the most curmudgeonly contact appreciates genuine offers of help. It’s important to make e-mails and phone calls feel personal. For example, you could send an e-mail saying, “I’ve heard through the grapevine that your business is having trouble, and as you know, I’ve dealt with this before, so please do call me if you want to vent or strategize or anything else.” In addition, he suggests that, when appropriate, humor is a great way to emphasize that you are being genuine and can make people feel comfortable.

Waldroop also advises that in certain cases it may be best to call after hours when you know the person won’t be in the office to pick up the phone. That way you can leave a message, which is less intrusive, and you won’t get interrupted before saying what you need to say.

Grow and Maintain the Network

In building your network, Professor Contractor believes that it’s vital to reach out to a diverse pool of people. Those who come from different fields, different socioeconomic backgrounds, and different countries can offer creative solutions and contacts that a colleague in the neighboring cubicle cannot.

Contractor has his students engage in the following exercise to assess how well they maintain their networks: Each student comes up with a “board of directors”—a list

of acquaintances they can call regarding important professional matters. Contractor then prompts his students to write out who introduced them to each person on the roster. “They will discover that, often, just a handful of people introduced them to the most important people in their lives,” he says. “These are people who ought to be cultivated because they are helping to broaden a network. One must make sure to continue to connect with those people.”

Some of Contractor’s students go through this exercise and find that they have been introducing themselves to their most valuable contacts. “That’s not a good sign,” Contractor says. “That means you’re not using your network well and you’re not tapping into the virtuous cycle.”

Principles to Remember

Do:

- Be genuine to gain credibility and sustain long-term relationships.
- Feed the network (via Twitter, Facebook, e-mails, etc.) to pass on useful information and show you are engaged.
- Offer to help using humor and tact.

Don’t:

- Focus on getting something immediately from a new contact.
- Hide behind technology and avoid face-to-face networking.
- Forget to read your audience and provide a personal approach.

Case Study 1: You Never Know Who Can Be Useful

When she was an executive at Allbritton Communications, Mary-Claire Burick, who is now president of her own strategic communications firm, went to a Washington, DC, Chamber of Commerce event and was seated next to the associate publisher of *DC* magazine. “I didn’t think much would come of it at the time, but I thought I’d keep in touch in the spirit of networking,” she recalls. Instead of just talking about superficial topics, she steered the conversation toward specific business issues and scheduled a follow-up meeting. In return, he invited her to company events where they continued to talk. Her

strategy was to be generous with her contacts and get to know the magazine community’s interests. A few months later, the publisher and Burick had the idea to create a segment for a show Burick’s company was launching. “We were able to brainstorm successfully because we had cultivated our relationship,” Burick said. The editor from *DC* magazine would appear every Friday on an Allbritton television program, helping Burick fill content spots and giving *DC* magazine exposure. Burick’s bosses were thrilled that she was able to launch the new show on a short timeline, and the editor introduced additional interviews to the show. “The relationship has also helped me in my new business, because I’ve met new clients through magazine events,” Burick says. “You just never know whom you are going to meet and how you will help each other in the future.”

Case Study 2: Job Search Equals Lifelong Network Creation

Meghna Majmudar was distraught when she heard the news that Katzenbach Partners, where she worked as senior associate, could no longer retain her. But a few days later, the managing partner of the firm sent her an e-mail saying that he wanted to meet for an hour to help her strategize about her job search and connect her with the right people. By the end of the meeting, she was given five names of people he would introduce her to in the coming weeks. From there, Majmudar spent the summer honing her networking. If she attended an event, she made sure to meet the organizer and e-mail feedback and thanks, which at least once led to a dinner with an important person in her field. If she went to a party, instead of asking for job titles, she’d ask people about their experiences to try to figure out if she could help them. “I shared my professional credentials and tried to find ways to connect on a personal level,” she says. “I realized that after a certain point of seniority, when someone likes you but has no open positions, they are really happy to offer career advice and introduce you to others.” Majmudar found that by being warm and discussing her passion for her work, she could get the right power players on her side and make use of high-level leads. “The people introducing me had a lot of cachet on their own, so I was able to draft off their value in my conversations.”

After three months, Majmudar landed a job she describes as “great,” and felt a renewed sense of confidence. “After a summer of networking, I have so much more energy and more resources to draw upon for future projects,” she says.

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6 Networking Mistakes and How to Avoid Them

Networking is one of the most effective ways to find a job, but most people dread it. Here's how to do it well—and enjoy it.

QUICK READ

How can you network effectively?

- Make a list of contacts, both personal and professional.
- Carefully prepare your introductory e-mail or phone call: Be clear and brief about your purpose.
- Sell yourself with crisp, concrete examples of your past accomplishments.
- Work the room: Talk with lots of people, ask about their jobs, give your 30-second elevator pitch.
- Don't criticize the company or person who laid you off.
- Say thank you and follow up.

by Gill Corkindale

Executive coach, former management editor of the Financial Times, and author of the blog, "Letter from London."

Find more content on managing yourself at blogs.hbr.org/cs

How to Start Looking for a New Job: Network, Network, Network

If you've been laid off in recent months, you're in excellent company. Plenty of qualified and experienced managers are now having to develop strategies to find their next jobs. But where to start? If you were my coaching client, I would simply say, Network, network, network.

Among my clients, however, networking is often an underdeveloped skill. Take Jerry, a 40-year-old business development manager in a financial services firm. His role is to build the business in Europe, so he has to make industry contacts, speak at conferences, and look for new client relationships. At this point in his career, he has to build internal networks, but instead of recognizing that he is already a master networker, the very mention of the word "network" makes him shudder. Why? Because in his mind, networking is associated with self-promotion, politics, and inappropriate favors.

In truth, networking is a critical skill for managers and leaders: Your network supports and sustains you in the good times, but is the key to your survival in the bad times.

But networking is difficult, even daunting, for managers who have no problem simply chatting with people. It doesn't need to be so stressful.

Here are some common mistakes people make when networking—and how to avoid them:

1. You think you don't know anyone. We live in a networked age, and most of us are connected to more people than we realize. Take 10 minutes to write a list of work colleagues (past and present), industry

contacts, friends, family, college alumni, and social acquaintances. You may surprise yourself. I recently coached a friend who claimed he had no contacts, but was still writing his list two hours after I prompted him!

Facebook and LinkedIn are powerful online gateways to contacts. See how far your network extends through your friends and colleagues. You may also have an online presence in the form of a blog or home page. See who has been corresponding with you lately. Online networking sites such as Free Agents and Ecademy are easy ways to make quick connections. Twitter is another useful social networking vehicle.

2. You don't know how to introduce yourself. It can be hard to introduce yourself if you've just been laid off. After all, you're probably used

to saying, "I'm so-and-so, and I work at such-and-such." If you don't currently have a job, be clear that you are in transition and looking for a new role. While you can refer back to what you did in your previous job, don't dwell on that. Instead, draw attention to your interests and skills in order to take the conversation forward.

Before you make a phone call or send an e-mail, consider your agenda and what you can realistically expect from the person. What's the purpose of your conversation—to find out information or to seek further contacts? Clarity about what you want will use your and the contact's time more effectively and will create a better impression than would a rambling speech. Be aware that your contacts may not be in a position to do much, so be gracious if all they can offer are ideas, advice, or their experience.

What people are saying on hbr.org

"I would add that an important networking tip is to know exactly what you want and be able to clearly articulate it in two sentences. 'Hi, my name is Suzy Smith, and I'm looking for my next job in account management in the ad agency industry.' This requires, of course, that you spend time after you've been laid off determining your next steps. Figure out what you want, and then practice saying it in a brief statement. Have fun with it if you can. Practice smiling as you say it, so that people get a sense of excitement and energy around your search.

Also ask, 'Why are you here today? What are you looking for?' of each person you meet. Who knows, you may refer a new client to someone, which will make you golden in this person's eyes!" —posted by Sharon

"Don't just network, network, network. Be very clear with yourself—and then those with whom you network—what your goal is. You can't just tell lots of people you are looking for a job and hope that they will magically see how your unique skill set matches some other unique job description. Make it very easy for them to see what you are hoping to get to and how you'd fit.

I get lots of queries from friends, and friends of friends: Do I know anything for so-and-so, who has great experience? It would help me a lot more if it was so-and-so, who has great experience and is looking for *this specific* kind of job or opportunity. Otherwise, we all end up wasting each other's time." —posted by Karen

"I would like to add, always project a good self-image. Be clean, have your clothes pressed and your shoes shined, be well groomed, keep your shoulders back and head up. And most important, when you shake someone's hand, look the person squarely in the eyes, have a firm 'full' handshake, do not be rushed, but don't linger. Also, always follow up promptly and personally." —posted by Ben

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Requesting a job isn't appropriate at this stage and may result in your losing the contact.

At the beginning of your phone call, ask if it's a convenient time for the person, and reschedule the call if necessary. If you're phoning or e-mailing someone you haven't met before, mention the person who gave you the contact's name and how you know that individual. Ask how he or she got into the job, what it involves, where vacancies are advertised, and how you might be considered for any roles if jobs are only advertised internally. Ask for an introduction to other useful contacts or for a follow-up meeting.

For networking e-mails, be personable and upbeat, but make sure your tone is appropriate for the person you are contacting. Don't go into "networking mode" if you are just reaching out to an old friend, for example.

3. You sound self-promoting. Networking is about selling yourself, but it can be hard to do that without sounding like a salesperson. No wonder so many people dread networking.

One way to *show* (rather than *tell*) people how great you are is to have a few "STAR" stories up your sleeve. STAR stands for situation, task, achievements, and results. It's an easy way to tell a concise story that lets your talents and achievements speak for themselves.

A STAR story should take no more than five minutes and should include enough detail to pique your contact's interest without overwhelming him or her. Here is an example:

Situation: The customer services division of your company was losing customers, had falling revenues (cite percentage decrease), and a conflict-ridden team (cite brief example).

Tasks: Your job was to stem the loss of customers, improve customer service, restructure the team, and develop new products.

Achievements: You held on to key accounts, resolved the conflict (explain how), rebuilt team morale (explain how), and increased the visibility and positive reputation of the department (explain how).

Results: The results were increased revenues (cite figures), a high-performing customer service team, innovative products (cite examples), and happy customers (cite examples).

4. You don't know how to work a room. If

you're going to an event, remember that there will be many others in the same situation—especially in a downturn—and that the purpose of the event is to circulate among people. Focus on other people by asking what they like about their job, how they got it, and what they would do if they were not in their current role. Exchange cards, and don't be embarrassed about moving on to the next person when the conversation is at a natural end.

5. You criticize the people or companies that laid you off. Think hard about how your story might sound to someone who has never met your nightmare former boss. Try to be positive, upbeat, and open about looking for work, but avoid sounding desperate or blaming the company or others for being laid off. This will leave a bad impression and could close off contacts before you can begin to develop a relationship.

6. You forget to say thank you. Good manners are critical for networking and are often overlooked, especially if you are under pressure to get a new job. Always thank your contacts for their time and advice, either in a handwritten note or with a follow-up e-mail. And keep in touch—send them an article or a notice of an event that might interest them. Keep in touch through social networking media, or drop them an occasional friendly e-mail telling them how you are getting on. Let them know when you do secure a job. This will help you maintain each contact as a member of your network—and allow you to return the favor when the contact is looking for a job down the road.

Finally, don't miss the opportunity to extend your network in even wider directions while you are unemployed. You might find this period in your life a surprising opportunity to consider different options, such as retraining or trying a new role (even a temporary one). Stay flexible and keep an open mind, and you might just find yourself in a better, more interesting career.

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The Best Cover Letter I Ever Received

by David Silverman

David Silverman has been an entrepreneur, an executive, and a business writing teacher. His latest book is Typo: The Last American Typesetter or How I Made and Lost 4 Million Dollars.

Find more content by David Silverman at blogs.hbr.org/silverman

Here's my basic philosophy on cover letters: Don't bother.

That's because the cover letters I see usually fall into one of three categories:

The recap: This is merely a résumé in prose form. It's redundant, harder to read than the résumé, and provides no additional insight.

The form letter: This says, essentially, "Dear Sir or Madam: I saw your ad in the paper and thought you might like me." And it's clearly a form letter—hopefully they got my name and company right.

The "I'm crazy": This one's rare, and it expands on the résumé of experience with some personal insights. Examples range from the merely batty ("I find batik as an art form has taught me to become both a better person and a stronger project manager.") to the truly terrifying ("I cast a pentagram hex and the central line pointed toward your job listing. I know you will find this as comforting as I do.").

There are really only a few times to use a cover letter:

1. when you know the name of the person hiring
2. when you know something about the job requirements
3. when you've been personally referred (which might include reasons 1 and 2)

Under those conditions, you can help your cause by doing some of the résumé analysis for your potential new boss. To illustrate, here's the best cover letter I ever received:

Dear David:

I am writing in response to the opening for X, a position I believe reports to you.

I can offer you seven years of experience managing communications for top-tier X firms, excellent project management skills, and a great eye for detail, all of which should make me an ideal candidate for this opening.

I have attached my résumé for your review and would welcome the chance to speak with you.

*Best regards,
Xxxx Xxxx*

Here's what I like about this cover letter: It's short. It sums up the résumé as it relates to the

job. It asks for the job.

The writer of this letter took the time to think through what would be relevant to me. Instead of scattering lots of facts in hopes that one was relevant, the candidate offered an opinion as to which experiences I should focus on.

And that means the writer isn't just showing me skills related to the job, he's showing me he'll be the kind of employee who offers solutions—instead of just laying problems on my desk.

What do you think? Have you ever secured a job thanks to a cover letter? What's your view on the value—or lack thereof—of cover letters?

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blogs.hbr.org/silverman

What people are saying on hbr.org

"The cover letter is your personal marketing flyer that indicates **all the features and benefits of you as a product**. It must be solution oriented, not problem oriented, in order to sell the product to the buyer—the hiring manager." —posted by Izzet

"The formal cover letter I always skip. I go straight to the résumé. Since I get most résumés via e-mail, it's better to type a quick paragraph saying how you know about the job and/or who referred you. That gets more weight from me than a multiparagraph formal letter or e-mail that summarizes the already summarized résumé.

Whatever you write, it has to get me to open your résumé. That is all that matters." —posted by Jarie

"I've received a couple of interviews over the years, and at least one job offer, on the basis of a good cover letter. I was young at the time, with little or no experience in the jobs I was applying for. My cover letter **focused on how I was educating myself to work toward the position and argued why they should hire me for any job**, so that I could work toward the desired position. In two cases my cover letter and résumé were referred to a hiring manager who had a job more appropriate to my skills but with room for growth. As a result, I spent seven years at one of those companies, taking advantage of many opportunities (none of which was the job I originally applied for)." —posted by Julie

"I'm currently hiring in China from a group of applicants who are from around the world. Cover letters are useful to me for a couple of reasons. First, **good ones are a sample of the person's writing skills** and an indicator of their level of written English. Also, letters tell me why the person thinks they are a good fit for the position, and they **show me that the person has thought about how their background matches our needs**.

That said, cover letters are not the norm in Asia, so I let my local colleagues review the résumés of local applicants and pick out people they think would impress me. I normally scan the e-mails of the local applicants as well to see if any stand out, but since cover letters are not part of the culture many great local applicants might be passed over for an interview if I stuck to my standards for U.S.-based applicants." —posted by Alicia

What people are saying on hbr.org, continued

“As someone who has been both a hiring manager and an applicant within the past year, here are my thoughts:

Ignore the cover letter at your own risk. Earlier this year we posted an entry-level position and received over 1,000 applications. The roughly half that came in without cover letters went into the trash sight unseen. Unfair? Maybe, but we needed some way to cut the list down. Anyone can forward a résumé, no matter how little they care about the job. Someone who took the time to write a cover letter has already displayed a higher interest level.

They’re not about you. My problem with too many cover letters (including the ‘good’ one shown earlier) is that they’re all about the applicant. **Companies don’t post jobs for your benefit; they post them because they have a need to fill.** A good cover letter at least makes an attempt to determine what that need is, and then addresses how your experience will help meet it. **It’s not your résumé in paragraph form.** Yes, a lot of cover letters just rehash what’s in the résumé. But that’s an argument for writing better cover letters, not ditching them entirely. Your cover letter should provide the context for your accomplishments that is not conveyed by bullet points.

If you can’t be good, be quick. I would guess that 90% of all cover letters don’t really say anything more than, ‘I’m applying for this job.’ If you can’t break out of that group, your best bet is to forget about quality and get your résumé in front of the hiring manager as quickly as possible. **Your chances of getting an interview are significantly higher if you’re one of the first résumés they see.** After they’ve already gotten a bunch of applicants, you’re either (a) being judged solely in relation to their top candidates, or (b) not being considered at all, because they’re already overwhelmed. Plus, your chances of getting an interview from a blind application aren’t very good to begin with, so you’re better off spending as little time as possible on that strategy and moving on to more productive job-search methods.” —posted by The Digitalists

“I view the cover letter as my sales pitch—why me, what distinguishes me from other candidates. I want to perk the reader’s interest and land the interview.” —posted by Kelsie

“If you are not networking your way into a company, then focus on using keywords frequently in your résumé and keep the cover letter brief. Here’s why.

In larger organizations this is often the screening process:

- HR clerk removes cover letters.
- Résumés are digitized in a scanner.
- **Digital résumés are screened and ranked with keyword software.** Ranking is by frequency of keywords found. (This is also how companies fish for résumés on most résumé-posting websites.)
- HR professional reviews and prints top-ranked résumés.” —posted by Michael

“My experience as a career management consultant shows that one of the best ways to write a cover letter is to use the ‘T’ format. In the body of the letter, **create a table that lists the main job requirements** on the left-hand side. Then, **to the right of each requirement, list your relevant skill or experience.** In this simple format it is easy for those hiring to see how your skills/experience directly match what they are looking for.” —posted by Leigh Ann

“A succinct, well-written cover letter that is laser-targeted to my specific job opening is rare and really gets my attention.

Case in point: A while back I received a cover letter for an IT programming position that was open. One candidate sent what I consider the best cover letter I have ever received. This person **listed every required qualification from the job posting and then gave a tight, well-written paragraph outlining exactly how he met each qualification.** This cover letter was admittedly longer than usual—about a page and a half—but by the time I finished reading it I was absolutely convinced he was the best candidate. I didn’t even need to read the résumé (although I did!). He was the first person I called in for an interview and I hired him.” —posted by Tom

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CONVERSATION STARTER

How to Write a Résumé That Doesn't Annoy People

by David Silverman

*David Silverman has been an entrepreneur, an executive, and a business writing teacher. His latest book is **Typo: The Last American Typesetter or How I Made and Lost 4 Million Dollars**.*

Find more content by David Silverman at blogs.hbr.org/silverman

A Google search for “résumé” results in over 178 million hits, whereas “possum” nets only 5,340,000. Thus the documentation of work experience is 33.3 times more popular than arboreal marsupials. But what does this really tell us? Not much, but neither does the average résumé that comes across my desk. Some excerpts:

- “Administered resolution of issues and implementation of ideas surfaced by individuals.”
- “Partaking in meetings designed to enhance collaboration, identify and develop strategies to ensure success regarding the accomplishment of goals.”
- “Experienced leader with superior interpersonal skills and business acumen talented at building productive relationships across a global organization.”

Huh?

We all know that currently more jobs are being lost than created, and that an opening will get dozens, if not hundreds, of applicants. But in our effort to avoid saying anything that might get our résumé tossed out of the pile, we often end up saying nothing at all.

Here are nine ways to make your résumé stand a better chance of survival:

1. Get the formatting right. Line up bullet points, dates, headings. Wacky spacing will raise questions about skills that have nothing to do with how you will perform on the job. And please learn to put dates flush against the right margin. The right-aligned tab stop remains a mystery as deep as an ocean for many résumé writers.

2. Insert dates for everything. If you've got a gap, explain it in your cover letter. But don't leave the dates off a job or a degree. Maybe you're worried they'll think you're too old or too young—but at best you'll look sloppy. At worst, sneaky.

3. Pile on the buzzwords. Yes, buzzwords are typically bad for clarity, but you have to get past the HR department first, and they're screening for matches with the words in the job description. Sarbanes-Oxley (SOX), consumer goods industry, certified project manager, SPL, BMN, FLB...whatever it is that matches the requirements, put it in.

4. Choose verbs that mean something. "Assisted," "worked on," "contributed to," and so on don't convey much to a prospective employer. Instead, say what you did: "wrote," "designed," or "managed." The more specific, the better.

5. Rewrite your résumé for each job application. If you really want a job, your prospective employer isn't going to be impressed by your inability to adjust one three-page document to address the company's needs. Highlight the top three to seven things you've done that match the requirements of the job.

6. State career objectives or outside interests—but be very careful. Do you know that they're looking for a "motivated team

player who wants to excel in international fashion and likes skiing and hot tubbing"? Great, put that in. Otherwise, save the nonjob stuff for the cover letter. Or better yet, the interview.

7. The older the job, the less detail you should have. Don't give 13 bullets on a job from 10 years ago.

8. Keep it short. A five-page résumé may be justified, but you've got to make it clear through headings and organization why you need so much space. If you have a list of publications or industry conference presentations, great, but put it at the end as a separate section. Consider the résumé of a CEO. He doesn't need to say that he attended meetings, assigned work, and similar basic tasks. He ran a company. One line.

9. Banish typos. Your résumé is like the restroom in a restaurant—as Anthony Bourdain says, it's the one room everyone sees. And if you can't keep that clean, what's it like in the kitchen?

What do you think? Are there things you see in résumés that cause you to toss them in the "probably not" pile? Have you ever had your résumé prevent you from getting a job?

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blogs.hbr.org/silverman

What people are saying on hbr.org

“For me, it’s all about the first 10 seconds. I want the page (or pages) to be visually appealing. Just enough white space but not too much. Part of the visual appeal **is being able to pick out the buzzwords and/or skills quickly.**

After the first 10-second scan, it’s all about the career story. Specific, tight descriptions of what this person has really done.

As for length, I never read past three pages. Even if the candidate has hundreds of published papers, I really don’t care. Tell me how many you have and then list the five to 10 most current.” —posted by Jarie

“Here are some additional items for your consideration:

- Even after you believe that you have perfectly set up the spacing, fonts, tabs, etc., **send it to yourself to make sure it is actually ending up in the receiver’s hands as you intend.** Always print it out as well.
- You should not have a job objective in today’s market. **A job objective is me-oriented.** The buyer does not care what you want; rather, they want someone who can do what they need done. A summary statement of how you can add immediate value and results is what’s needed.
- **You must have meaningful results.** Most lists of accomplishments say what the person did but not what the results were. Read your list and at the end of each statement add the results of that effort. Dollars saved? On-time results? More widgets made?
- Under each employer **include a small blurb describing the business and its size:** for example, ‘nuclear engineering company with 4,500 global employees.’
- **Leave out ‘references available upon request’** or similar offerings.”

—posted by Howard

“If I am reviewing a résumé for an engineering or other technical position, I look first for **conciseness and organizational ability** (e.g., meaningful bullet lists, well-designed sections with clear headings).

If I am looking to fill a more people-oriented position such as administrative assistant, I want to see more of the person’s story and other signs of **relational skills.**”

—posted by Ken

“**The best résumé I ever wrote included a section on failures.** It impressed the CEO who hired me because I stated what was learned from each failure. The failure section separated me from the crowd.” —posted by Gary

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How to Perfect an Elevator Pitch About Yourself

You're in the elevator with the hiring manager of Dream-Job Corporation. You've got 15 seconds to convince this person to hire you. What are you supposed to say?

QUICK READ

An elevator pitch is a critical tool for successful networking. Here's how to fine-tune yours:

- Toot your own horn.
- State in one concrete sentence what makes you so effective ("I can make any boss shine").
- Deliver your pitch calmly and confidently.
- Practice, practice, practice—100 times.
- Give your pitch to everyone, wherever you go.

by Daisy Wademan Dowling

Executive coach, regular contributor to Harvard Business Review, and author of the blog "Getting Ahead."

Find more content on managing yourself at blogs.hbr.org/dowling

You're in the elevator with the hiring manager of Dream-Job Corporation. As the door slides shut, you feel a combination of adrenaline and slight nausea: You've got 15 seconds, if that, to communicate your value as a potential employee in a compelling way—just 15 seconds to cram in a whole résumé's worth of work and accomplishments and late nights and successes. There's so much you want to say, but your message has got to be crisp, tailored, and to the point. Handle this one right, and you'll be the newest member of the Dream-Job team. Flub it up, and you're back to scanning listings on Monster.com. What are you supposed to say?

Here are five ways to make your elevator pitch successful:

Focus on your positive impact

Two weeks ago, *60 Minutes* aired a segment set at a white-collar job fair. One of the interviewees, a laid-off Wall Street secretary, looked straight into the camera and said, with total conviction, "I can make any boss shine." I wanted to hire her on the spot. Who doesn't want to shine? Describing the

impact you've had, and can continue to have, is much more compelling than talking about your number of years of experience.

To make a compelling, one-sentence encapsulation of who you truly are and what you can offer, you need to think hard about three characteristics of your statement:

- It needs to be utterly genuine. What do you think your value to an employer really is? What has made you the proudest in your work life? What do you love to do? If you focus on those things, your energy will come through.
- The statement should focus on things that most managers and leaders find difficult or otherwise grapple with. What thorny problem can your particular talents solve?
- The statement should paint a rosy picture of the future for the hiring manager, for the corporation, or for both. Who doesn't want to shine?

Here are a few examples that I have heard in the past and found compelling. They are specific, but then again, all personal taglines need to be.

- "My specialty is taking messy and complex processes and streamlining them."
- "I can teach any junior person how to

work effectively with data and numbers."

- "I'm a 'fixer.' I've turned around distressed businesses and departments before, and those are the situations I thrive in."
- "My core skill is gathering information, often from people who don't want to give it up. I'm persistent, curious, effective—and I dig deep."

Focus on "I," not "we"

A lot of us have been taught—by parents, teachers, or team-oriented corporate environments—not to toot our own horns and to use "we" instead of "I." Elevator pitches are all about "I." You've got to get comfortable with boasting about your own individual contributions (albeit gracefully).

Be slow and steady

Whether out of nervousness or a desire to cram a lot of information into a pitch, people giving elevator speeches tend to talk at breakneck pace—which is extremely off-putting to potential employers. Speak at a pace that shows you're calm and confident. You want the listener to think of you as thoughtful and deliberate—not as some manic babbler.

See the whole world as an elevator

Too many people looking for jobs save their elevator speeches for job fairs and interviews. Remember the first rule of sales: ABC (always

What people are saying on hbr.org

"I love the comment 'I can make any boss shine.' That's great! She promised a benefit, which is a compelling technique. Another suggestion is to make your elevator pitch about 'who you are' versus 'what you do.' Think about powerful words that describe your personality and work style, such as 'ethical,' 'driven,' 'collaborative,' or 'disciplined'—words that will allow the person to feel what it would be like to work with you. And finally, be passionate about yourself and your career search, and make sure this passion comes through in your elevator speech." —posted by Sharon

"Be sure you know what to say if your 15 seconds turns into 15 minutes. It's one thing to say, 'I can make anyone shine,' but if you don't know specific details (and have them equally well rehearsed), you won't get to a more formal conversation." —posted by Scott

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be closing). Give your elevator speech to everyone—at family gatherings, in the waiting room of the dentist, at coffee hour at your place of worship. You never know where the next job is coming from.

Practice, practice, practice

Few people have the oratorical power to make a persuasive 15-second speech about their entire professional lives on demand and under pressure. Practice your speech 100 times—literally. Know it, get comfortable with it, be able to tilt it effectively for a different audience. Consider your body language when practicing: How will you give the speech differently sitting down versus walking down a hall? How will it be different over the phone and in person?

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blogs.hbr.org/cs

7 Ways to Shine in an Interview

by David Silverman

*David Silverman has been an entrepreneur, an executive, and a business writing teacher. His latest book is **Typo: The Last American Typesetter or How I Made and Lost 4 Million Dollars**.*

Find more content by David Silverman at blogs.hbr.org/silverman

Through a combination of skill, perseverance, and luck, you've landed a job interview. In short order, you'll face a series of hard-nosed questioners with no recourse to the backspace key to fix any verbal gaffes. Now what?

Understand that the interviewer wants to figure out if you're the best match for the job. To do that, the interviewer will rely on his or her perceptions and beliefs about interviewing.

For example, I like to know that an employee has a desire to get promoted and move ahead. My reasoning is that an employee who mentions promotion in the interview will work harder on the job.

But other interviewers may have had a bad experience with an employee who focused on advancement to the exclusion of finishing the job they were hired to do. If you're not sensitive to that manager's fears, and continue talking about how you're getting your MBA at night, you won't get that job.

So with that thought in mind—that you need to listen and react to the person in the room with you, not slavishly follow any list of rules—I present my list of rules for interviewing:

- 1. Dress appropriately.** If you're going to Amalgamated Ginormous Finance, Inc., a business suit is appropriate. If you're a man, wear a tie. Even in California.
- 2. Shut up.** Did I tell you about the time someone came and told me his life story for 45 minutes and then allowed me 10 minutes to explain the job? I think you know how that story ends.
- 3. Listen.** The most useful skill in sales is listening—and in an interview, you're selling yourself. If you say, "I think the best computers in the world are PCs and people who use Macs have more

style than substance” after the interviewer mentions his iPhone, you could be left with your opinion and no job.

4. Ask questions. You can avoid the preceding problem by responding to the question, “Do you think we should scrap all the PCs here and buy Macs?” by saying, “That depends on lots of factors. What are your requirements?”

5. Show interest. This could also be called “sucking up.” When an interviewee doesn’t ask me anything about myself, she’s not just saying, “I’ve got pride in my accomplishments and I don’t need to pander to you.” She’s also telling me that she isn’t good at showing interest in other people. Which means she’s going to have a hard time politically in the company. And since that’s going to reflect badly on me...no job for her.

6. Do your research. Some people find being Googled creepy. But if you do it carefully, you can show the hiring manager that you took the time to learn something about him. Feel free

to quote what he said in *CIO* magazine about the challenges of technology in the office. Just don’t mention the size of his swimming pool as viewed through Google Earth.

7. Answer the question you wish they’d asked. How many times have you left an interview thinking, “I never got a chance to tell them about my Nobel Prize in possum research?” Don’t wait for the question. Answer “What did you do at your last job?” with “Actually, it was my work on possums two jobs ago that you might find most relevant.” (Maybe for you it wasn’t specifically a Nobel or about possums, but you get the idea.)

What about you? Any horror stories of interviews gone wrong as either the interviewee or interviewer? Any thoughts on how to stand the best chance of success in an interview?

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blogs.hbr.org/silverman

What people are saying on hbr.org

“Be courteous to the interviewer’s support staff—secretaries, assistants, etc. Even though they may not be able to put in a good word for you, if you rub them the wrong way, they may mention their negative impression.” —posted by Crystal

“In my experience, **behavioral interviewing** is popular and very effective. The focus is on how you have handled situations and people in the past. The interviewers are listening for how you will perform in the future. I have seen many folks try to answer these questions and crash and burn on the spot because they anticipated discussing only what appeared on their résumés.” —posted by Martin

“Having a conversation during an interview is a good signal for the kind of conversation we’ll have if you get the position. I’m looking for people who would like to have my job, because that means they want to be a strategic thinker, a doer, committed, etc. They may not ultimately have what it takes, but having that desire in the first place is important. If someone doesn’t ask about career path, I am left wondering what kind of a proactive initiative-taker they are.

Finally, **interviewing is marketing: You have to know everything you can about the customer.** It is *not* sucking up to interviewers to ask questions about their personal experience. It is being engaged and interested and possibly getting insight that you would otherwise have to root out of a corporate website.” —posted by Kate

“If you have the chance, offer a **brief summary of who you are and what you’ll do for the company**—it’s a very powerful parting message.” —posted by drliz

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How to Ace an Interview

You get an interview through connections or maybe your résumé. You get a job through body language and a few compelling stories.

by Nick Morgan

Nick Morgan is President of Public Words Inc., a communications consulting firm, and author of Trust Me: Four Steps to Authenticity and Charisma.

Think of a job interview as having two purposes:

1. Establishing basic trust with the interviewer.
2. Giving the interviewer a few clear ideas about what you can do for the company.

Achieving both of these goals when you're under pressure takes some planning and advance work. At the most fundamental level, you need to figure out how to align yourself with both the interviewer and the company. So begin by finding out as much as you can about both. Look for things you have in common with the person interviewing you and values you share with the company. Once you've done your homework, you're ready to focus on the interview itself.

A Question of Trust

Your primary goal is to establish basic trust with the interviewer. You have only a short time to do so, and it is essential.

There isn't much science to interviewing; most interviewers have little idea of what they're doing beyond asking some pet questions and coming away with a "gut feeling" about the person. So give your interviewer a good gut feeling. Project trustworthiness.

How do you accomplish that difficult feat when you're nervous and on the spot? If you're a natural actor, the task is simple. Act comfortable, poised, and friendly. Mirror the body language of the interviewer, especially when she is being open with you. If her body language is reserved or hostile—say, her arms are crossed and she's half turned away from you—don't mirror that. Wait for a moment of openness.

Get in the right frame of mind, and your body language will send the right trust messages.

This kind of acting is difficult to do, however, and most of us don't do it very well. But if you prepare yourself mentally and emotionally, the body language will follow. Look for ways in which you and the interviewer are alike and talk about them; your body language will then naturally copy hers. Don't just settle for finding favorite sports teams in common, though; this is superficial stuff. Look for experiences or passions you both share.

Even better is to discover work-related interests in common and focus on the emotional currents that drive those. Do you both have a passion for creating order out of chaos? Are you list-driven, or are you creative types who like to take each day as it comes?

You can't simply ask these questions; the topics have to come up in anecdotes, examples, and stories that reveal how the interviewer thinks. In short, you have to interview the interviewer. Which leads to the second point.

Lay Out What You Can Do

Your resume lists all your accomplishments. But they're in the past. What you need to communicate is how you are going to help the company in the future. The way to start is by doing your homework on the company. Find out how you can help. Then match three ideas with your experience where you've done something like it in the past.

Think of your experiences as potential parables—stories with a moral. Anecdotes quickly become maddening when they are not sufficiently pointed. How many times has your mind wandered seconds into this kind of story?

Last Wednesday—or was it Tuesday? No, it was Wednesday, because my wife always takes the boys to Scouts on Wednesday. I was talking to my friend Bill—or was it Jim? Yes, it was Jim because he was running ragged that day....

You get the idea. We're a minute into the story and we don't even have the beginnings of a glimmer of a point on the horizon. It is good to personalize stories—make them about you or someone you know. But personal stories have to be especially well shaped, or the interviewer won't be able to bear to listen to them.

In an interview, the stakes are very high. Make your stories do double duty, at the least. They

should illustrate the good job you'll be able to do for the company if you're hired. And they should have an emotional subtext that shows you to be loyal, trustworthy, a hard worker—some personal quality you need to get across.

You should prepare one story that highlights a significant failure you've had, a story that shows you learning from your mistakes. Why a failure? Some interviewers may ask about a failure you've experienced, and if you're not prepared, your answer may harm rather than help you. Other interviewers will appreciate the subtext: That you're big enough to admit to making mistakes and to learn from them. This will magnify you in the interviewer's mind, not diminish you. And such stories have the charm of the unexpected during an interview. Your goal in these situations is first not to give the interviewer a reason to eliminate you, and second to give him some reason to remember you, to make yourself stand out in some way from the herd.

Finally, prepare some specific questions for the interviewer. When the interviewer asks, "Now what questions do you have for us?" nothing is more lame than saying, "Uh, I don't really have any, I guess." So be prepared to ask specific questions that your research has unearthed. What was the thinking behind a marketing campaign? A new product launch? How well does the company's vision line up with its actual activities? And always have questions like the following up your sleeve:

- What would constitute success in this job?
- Can you give me an example of a significant failure someone on the team has experienced?
- What happened? Was the employee punished?

Now go interview with confidence. Lean forward, show some excitement, and tell the interviewer how the experience you gained herding llamas in Peru can help her company thrive in the difficult economic environment we find ourselves in. Perhaps herding llamas is ideal training for becoming an excellent project manager, one who brings costs down and speeds up completion times. Be as specific as you can, especially if invited to by the interviewer.

Don't overpromise. But this is not a time to be shy. It's unlikely that others will recognize your hidden promise if you don't point it out. Especially if your experience doesn't precisely match the new job, you'll need to do some bridging and explaining to show why you can succeed in the new environment.

Get in the right frame of mind, and your body language will send the right trust messages. Go in armed with what you can do for the company, and you'll get the offer. What you do with the offer is up to you.

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Five Questions About... Interviewing Your Prospective Supervisor

with Rich Wellins

Senior Vice President, Development Dimensions International

There is nothing more important than an employee's relationship with her boss.

Numerous studies have shown that it is the linchpin of great performance, long-term commitment, and employee satisfaction at all levels of the organization. But although most hiring managers will look at the personality fit between themselves and job candidates, few prospective employees give this component very much consideration—often to their regret if they discover later on that they and their supervisors are mismatched.

There are ways for job candidates to hedge against this fate, says Rich Wellins, whose work at Pittsburgh-based human resources firm Development Dimensions International (DDI) focuses on helping companies put the right people in the right seats. His advice about how to initiate frank discussions with prospective supervisors— and how to get telltale glimpses into their personality—is as relevant to considering a new internal assignment as it is to interviewing for a position in a different company.

1. Why is it important for job candidates to interview their potential boss?

The primary reason people leave jobs is because of their relationship with their supervisor. It's not because of pay, benefits, or even because of the organizational department; rather, it's because they are not getting along with their supervisor.

Interviewing the prospective supervisor gives the candidate a better opportunity to determine whether this is the sort of person that he can respect and develop a good rapport with. If he feels there's a good fit with the supervisor, then, if he's hired, he's going to be a happier, more engaged employee.

2. Won't a manager who needs to fill the position tend to be less than candid?

You're not going to eliminate that completely, but a way to get around it is to ask for specifics. Four or five key questions should give you a good handle on the supervisor's style.

Questions such as, "What sort of working style do you have?" or "Do you believe empowerment is important?" or "Do you have opportunities for growth and development?" won't do the trick. Instead, ask for specific examples: "How have you successfully mentored someone on your team? How have you helped someone achieve her professional goals? Can you give me examples of techniques you used to get your team to collaborate better?"

3. Any particulars you should look for?

Pretty much everybody wants opportunities for growth. And no one wants to be micromanaged. Also, does the supervisor have good listening skills? And do the types of questions he asks indicate that he's genuinely interested in you and in having the best possible working relationship with you?

Beyond these things, there aren't any universal attributes to look for. It's more a matter of determining the optimal conditions for you as an individual. For some employees, it's essential to have a boss who'll give them a lot of coaching. For others, that may not be as important as having a great deal of independence.

4. Can you make reliable inferences based on the way a supervisor interacts with her team?

It's doubtful that you'll get much of a chance to do that, beyond perhaps seeing how she interacts with other employees. But even that can be significant—the way she treats those people tells you something about her social intelligence.

It is totally appropriate, however, especially if you're in the buyer's seat, to ask if you can interview a few people who work for the supervisor. Doing that can give you a much fuller picture of the job's challenges and opportunities.

5. Are there more indirect ways of discovering what the supervisor is really like?

What do the potential supervisor's tone and manner tell you? Does he answer your questions? Pay attention to his nonverbal communication, too. For example, does he maintain eye contact? What does he have on his desk? All these things can tell you a little bit about his values, personality, and management style. In addition, look at how you've been treated throughout the interview process. You'll find clues here about not only your potential boss but also the organizational culture.

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How to Ask for a Reference Letter

by Jodi Glickman Brown

Jodi Glickman Brown is a speaker, author, and entrepreneur. She is the founder of the communication consulting firm Great on the Job.

In the 2009 film *Up in the Air*, Natalie Keener decides she can no longer stomach being part of a corporate firing squad and quits her firm. Her mentor, played by George Clooney, writes a glowing reference letter on her behalf, addressed simply “To whom it may concern.”

In the real world, getting a reference letter is far more difficult and often a source of much anxiety. Whom to ask, how to ask, what to say?

But getting an outstanding reference letter is entirely within your control and easier than you think, even if you don’t have a benevolent benefactor at your back.

Here are three tips to ensure that your mentor, former boss, or academic counselor writes you a rave review:

1. Highlight your reviewer’s qualifications.
2. Provide a template.
3. Offer a “no questions asked” policy.

Let’s look at each of these individually.

Highlight Your Reviewer’s Qualifications

When reaching out to ask for a letter of reference, explain up front why you value that person’s opinion and respect her professional expertise enough to choose her (of all people) to vouch for you in your next professional endeavor.

Beyond mere flattery, show why you think that person is uniquely qualified to accurately assess and communicate your personal contribution to your future organization. Why did you enjoy working for her? Why do you look up to her? How do her qualities match your own, or speak to

the authority you want your recommendation to convey?

Provide a Template

It's almost impossible to get a good reference letter from someone if you don't provide the tools necessary for him to actually write a good letter. It's also terribly inconsiderate not to give ample guidance. The last thing anyone wants is to spend hours or days thinking about and drafting a letter that you yourself could have composed far better in half the time.

Providing a template—an outline, bullet points, or even a fully baked draft—of what you'd like the reference letter to say is the most effective (not to mention generous and thoughtful) approach to asking for a letter of reference. The goal isn't to put words into your former colleague's mouth or to co-opt him into vouching for you in an untrue or disingenuous manner; it's simply to do some of the work for him and provide all of the pertinent data points that you'd like included in the letter. Moreover, as boastful as you may feel writing your own referral, remember that people will often follow your lead in writing a reference. In fact, they are likely to be even more generous than you propose in praising your skills and contribution to an organization. So go ahead and toot your own horn.

Offer a “No Questions Asked” Policy

Finally, once you provide your reviewer with a useful template and make it clear that your intention is to make this process as painless as possible, it's time to hand over the reins and offer a “no questions asked” policy. First, give your colleague an easy “out” to decline your

request for any or no reason. Then, assuming she agrees, give her ample leeway to change, modify, or edit your letter as she sees fit. You want to convey a sense of trust and allow her to write a letter she is entirely comfortable with.

Let's take a look at what this request might actually look like.

Highlight His Qualifications

Dear John,

Hello, I hope you are well. I am writing to ask a huge favor—I'm applying for a senior marketing position with Merck and I am hoping you'll consider writing a letter of recommendation on my behalf. I always appreciated your perspective and judgment while working together. You have so much credibility within the product development space that I thought you'd be a perfect person to act as a reference.

Provide a Template

I have included a list of bullet points along with a draft letter you might consider using as a template. I'd like to make the process as easy as possible for you, and I know it's hard to recall details about the many different projects we worked on together in 2007 and 2008.

“No Questions Asked”

If for any reason you don't feel comfortable writing a letter on my behalf, I completely understand. If you are willing to do so, however, please feel free to take the attached sample letter and use it as a template as you see fit. I have tried to address my core strengths as a strategic thinker and team player and I have highlighted several marketing campaigns I'm particularly proud of. Please make any changes

What people are saying on hbr.org

“I've found LinkedIn to be an excellent source for recommendations as well; I've asked for several through that network. This gives the prospective author of the recommendation a chance to write a brief general version of what you want him/her to draft later. That said, I've found that a bulleted list of specific achievements, perhaps even coupled with a few fun anecdotes, goes a long way toward getting an effective recommendation.”

—posted by PT

Join the discussion at blogs.hbr.org/cs

or modifications to the letter that you wish. Understandably, you'll want to include only those topics you feel comfortable commenting upon.

Further, while I would welcome the opportunity to see a copy of the letter, I of course understand if you'd like to keep it confidential.

Finally, finish your request with all the grace and charm you can muster—thank the other person profusely for his time and help and offer to make yourself available for any further questions he may have.

Posted April 7, 2010
blogs.hbr.org/silverman

Five Ways to Bungle a Job Change

Research shows that even very seasoned executives frequently make unfortunate and ill-considered career moves.

by Boris Groysberg and Robin Abrahams

The average baby boomer will switch jobs 10 times, according to the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. The worker as free agent—a concept popularized in the 1990s—remains a reality regardless of economic conditions, making it incumbent on all of us to take greater control of our own careers. The corporate ladder is still being disassembled like a Jenga tower, and even the CEO position is no longer a terminus. As one independent financier we interviewed put it, “[T]here are no final destinations. [Your career] is a process of continuous development.”

But while job moves are just about inevitable, they are seldom easy and nearly always emotionally fraught—and too often they lead to a noticeable decline in performance, in both the short and the long term. For instance, in previous research we found that star equities analysts moving to new investment banks experienced drops in performance that lasted as long as five years. People who switch organizations—whether they’re wide receivers changing football teams or general managers going to new companies—all face similar problems. It’s not just about the learning curve. Moves of all kinds entail significant internal and external challenges and transaction costs: upheaval in your home and social life; potential relocation expenses; adjustments to new cultural and political norms; navigation of unclear expectations; and the need to learn a new canon, skill set, and jargon.

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Debating the merits of a particular offer might seem like a luxury when jobs are scarce. And of course there are times when you have no choice but to accept a less-than-perfect fit for financial reasons. Even so, a job is never just a job. This is your *career* we're talking about. The occasional misstep can be forgiven, but a careful and conscious assessment of the risks and realities will help you avoid making too many mistakes or ones that amount to a major setback.

The Most Common Missteps

To identify the most frequent job-hopping errors, we analyzed data from three research streams: a survey of executive search consultants, a survey of HR heads at multinational companies, and interviews with C-level executives around the world. (See "About Our Research.")

The job-change mistakes we outline in this article are by far the ones most commonly cited by the search consultants; the themes are echoed in the HR heads' survey comments and in the executives' stories about their best and worst decisions. The mistakes are: not doing enough research, leaving for money, going "from" rather than "to," overestimating yourself, and thinking short term. They follow predictable patterns and persist throughout the course of a career.

These mistakes are not independent of one another; they play out as a system of maladaptive behaviors, dissatisfaction, unrealistic hopes, ill-considered moves, and more dissatisfaction. Fixating on money, for instance, can obscure the need for research. Overestimating yourself can cause you to ignore a bad fit—a problem that research might have helped you anticipate. Some job seekers make all five mistakes at once: Because they overvalue themselves, they feel unjustly treated at year-end review time and leave for the first company that promises a signing bonus, without doing due diligence on the firm's long-term prospects.

The executives we surveyed and spoke to were not young, untested managers. We zeroed in on seasoned individuals (mostly in the C-suite) with substantial experience making hiring decisions of their own at the very highest levels. But, as one search consultant reminded us, many successful people haven't looked for a job for years—sometimes decades— and thus

are surprisingly ignorant about job-market realities. In the words of another consultant, "They assume that companies will be as flexible about having them learn new areas of business as they were when they were young." They have unrealistic expectations about how long it will take to find a job, and if they're high up in the hierarchy, it may have been some time since they received truly honest feedback about their strengths and weaknesses. That's one reason they stumble into such predictable traps. (The blame doesn't fall solely on the recruits, though. Companies chase these stars, hoping to simply plug them into an existing org chart. Too often, they are minimally strategic in their selection and even less strategic in integrating their new hires.)

Mistake 1: Not doing enough research. Search consultants told us that job hunters neglect due diligence in four important areas.

First, they often don't do their homework on the job-market realities for their industry or function. Since they're not fully informed, they have unrealistic expectations when it comes to the search.

Second, they don't pay enough attention to a potential employer's financial stability and market position. Executives who would scrutinize the balance sheet of any firm they might acquire nevertheless assume that companies offering them a job must be on solid ground. Yet plenty of businesses will hire for senior jobs even when they know there's trouble ahead, so it's up to the applicant to assess how likely it is that the new job will still exist in six months.

Third, executives fail to consider cultural fit. Although hiring managers are supposed to attend to that, they often don't—and it's the new hire who will suffer most if the fit is a poor one.

Fourth, recruits assume that the official job title and description accurately reflect the role. But companies have been known to sweeten a title to attract top talent. Additionally, in a badly managed organization, people may find themselves in ill-defined jobs that have little relationship to their formal titles. One executive described his worst career move as leaving one company for a much smaller firm, where he was given the CFO title even though the bulk of his duties were really those of a COO. He found

it hard to establish the credibility he needed to get the job done, given the misalignment of his tasks and title. Job candidates frequently fail to press potential employers for such specifics, including how their performance will be measured. Without that information, the success of any move depends on the luck of the draw.

Mistake 2: Leaving for money. It's easy to fall for a financially attractive offer. Search consultants told us that executives contemplating a job change rank income fourth or fifth in terms of importance but bump it to first place when making their decision. Our executive interviewees occasionally owned up to this error. Here's how the vice president of talent and engagement at an international casino company characterized his own move based on pay: "I was doing the identical role for \$10K more, but leaving behind the relationships and connections was just not worth it in hindsight." Excessive focus on money is a frequently cited reason for inadequate research. "Opportunity for advancement and more money overrides the need to pursue core information," said one search consultant.

Mistake 3: Going "from" rather than "to." Often, job seekers have become so unhappy with their present positions that they are desperate to get out. Instead of planning their career moves, they lurch from one place to the next, applying artificial urgency to the job hunt rather than waiting for the right offer. Candidates not only skimp on research in the belief that the grass has to be greener elsewhere but also fail to look strategically at their current companies for opportunities that might still exist for them.

Mistake 4: Overestimating yourself. According to one search consultant, people "believe they contribute more than they actually do and undervalue the strengths of their organization in helping them achieve their objectives." Job seekers, we found, tend to have an unrealistic view of their skills, their prospects, and occasionally their culpability. They often can't identify the sources of success and failure at their existing jobs. Candidates are "looking at the current company as being the problem and not acknowledging that they themselves may be a part of the problem," one consultant explained. Another put it this way: "People fail to be realistic sometimes [and] to be self-critical, and [they therefore think] that external

About Our Research

For this article, we conducted a survey of 400 executive search consultants from more than 50 industries, interviews with more than 500 C-level executives in 40 countries, and a survey of HR heads at 15 multinational companies.

The search consultants had extensive experience placing the best and brightest: In our sample, 67% had 10-plus years of experience, and 70% recruited for stars at the senior-executive level or higher. We asked the consultants to name the most common mistakes people make when contemplating a job change and the reasons for those mistakes. We posed similar questions to the HR heads. The interviews with executives were conducted by students in Boris Groysberg's 2008 class Managing Human Capital.

The consultants referred to a total of 738 mistakes. The top five kinds discussed in this article represent nearly two-thirds of them: We had 127 references to not doing enough research, 117 to leaving for money, 104 to going "from" rather than "to," 76 to overestimating yourself, and 60 to thinking short term.

The smaller survey of HR heads matched the consultants' feedback almost perfectly. Out of a total of 15 responses, not doing enough research was mentioned five times; leaving for money and going "from" rather than "to," three times each; overestimating yourself, twice; and thinking short term, once.

circumstances and environments have more to do with their frustrations or failures than their own issues."

Their excessively optimistic view of themselves leads them to underestimate how long a job search will take and what the switching costs will be. Such job seekers also overestimate the salary they can command and their capacity to deal with the challenges of the new position—particularly the difficulty of creating change in a large organization. This last error resonated with many of the executives we interviewed. One software CFO regretted taking a job at a large multinational, where it was "so much bigger, more unwieldy, difficult to make an impact, and impersonal," he says. "No matter what I did, it didn't make a difference."

Mistake 5: Thinking short term. Having a short-term perspective can feed into each of the other four mistakes. For instance, if you overestimate yourself, you may believe you deserve rewards now, not in five years. Leaving a firm because of money and going "from" rather than "to" are both overly influenced by

Do at least as much research on a company you're planning to join as you would on a financial investment.

immediate information and considerations. “How much money can I make right now?” the executive wonders. “How can I escape an unpleasant work environment?” Still, many of the search consultants rated short-term thinking as a serious career misstep in its own right—citing it separately, not just including it as a footnote to the other mistakes.

Making Moves Under Pressure

Job seekers' mistakes aren't random. All of us feel certain psychological, social, and time pressures that can lead to any of the five we've described. Though nobody is immune, we can ask questions of ourselves and others to help ameliorate these pressures' effects.

Psychological pressure. We are all motivated to maintain a sense of psychological safety by nurturing a positive self-image, by looking at the world as a knowable and predictable place, and by avoiding risk. This can lead to an overestimation of the self and to a habit of attending only to information that bolsters your existing beliefs. Psychologists call this selective attention “confirmation bias,” and it can play havoc with a strategic job search. A hiring company presumably wants to present itself in the most flattering light, and if a candidate is motivated to move, he or she will be more than willing to see only the bright side.

Our self-protective desires go beyond the ego. We also seek to protect our material wellbeing by minimizing losses. Because what people give up when they leave a job is so clear (at the very worst, it's still the devil you know), excessive focus on short-term rewards and money may be a way of hedging against long-term risks that cannot really be evaluated.

Here are the fundamental questions to ask through every step of the job-change process: “What if I'm wrong? What is the evidence that this new company would be a good fit?” Do at least as much research on a company you're planning to join as you would on a company you're planning to buy stock in. Develop alternative scenarios. Consider how you'd feel about your present job if your boss left, for instance, or if the company secured an enticing new client. And rethink self-serving interpretations of events—how, for example, did your colleagues contribute to your success? This is difficult work, and it's tough to manage by yourself.

Many of the executives we interviewed rely on a mentor, network, or personal “board of directors” to provide this kind of reality check.

Social pressure. Awkward social situations can trigger fight-or-flight instincts, putting strategic thinking squarely on the back burner—and they frequently lead people to make “from” rather than “to” decisions. The CFO of a marketing agency recounts such a situation from his own career, in which he changed jobs rather than have an awkward conversation or two: “Even though I enjoyed the company and had a great relationship with the CFO, I never spoke with him about my concerns before quitting. In retrospect, I realize that the CFO could have been instrumental in advancing my career within that company. If I had stayed...I could see myself being very happy and secure today.”

Stress management techniques like yoga and meditation can help alleviate this kind of social anxiety. So can rehearsing difficult conversations, alone or with a partner. By practicing clear communication, and by repeatedly restating your concerns, you can suppress your emotional reactions and remain rational in an actual conversation. Through candid conversations with colleagues or your boss, you might be able to redeem your current job rather than make an ill-advised change.

If you are seriously contemplating a move, don't be afraid to ask tough questions at a job interview. When an interviewer can't handle direct, relevant questions, what does that say about the corporate culture?

Social discomfort intimidates us far beyond its power to harm us; as is widely known, most people rank public speaking as a fear greater than death. Deconstructing such irrational fear can help free you from the social pressures that may lead you to make hurried, unhappy career moves.

Time pressure. A hasty job change, made with insufficient information, is inherently compromised. When under time pressure, people tend to make certain predictable mistakes. They focus on readily available details like salary and job title instead of raising deeper questions, and they set their sights on the immediate future, either discounting or misreading the long term. Many also have an egocentric bias,

thinking only of what affects them directly and ignoring the larger context.

Nonetheless, a career move will always involve some time pressure. To manage it, one COO in our study says he always keeps an ear to the ground with respect to industry trends, both in the U.S. and abroad. He explains that this is a way to stay ahead of the curve when it comes to career decisions. But no matter how well informed you are, you need strategies to jar yourself out of traditional ways of thinking and to make sure you aren't heeding only the nearest, loudest, quickest source of information. With the help of your mentor or network, create a list of unknowns. Engage in counterfactual- thinking exercises: Consider whether you'd take the new job if the salary were the same as your current pay. Plot the most likely three-year trajectory at each company, working out the most optimistic and pessimistic scenarios. What decision would be right in each situation?

What if you do take the wrong job? The executives we interviewed were unanimous in their

views: Cut your losses and move on. Fleeing to another bad situation is not the answer, though. We suggest making your next move strategically—and wherever you are in the search process, don't hesitate to go down another road if it becomes evident that a certain kind of change wouldn't be right.

Perhaps the best protection against career-management mistakes is self-awareness. It's a broad concept, encompassing not only an understanding of your career-relevant strengths and weaknesses but also insight into the kinds of mistakes you are prone to make. It involves knowing how to correct for those tendencies, how others perceive you, when to consult a trusted mentor or network, what elements of a job make it truly satisfying for you, and what constitutes a healthy work-life balance.

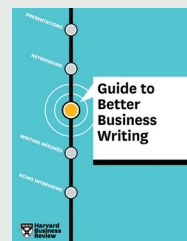
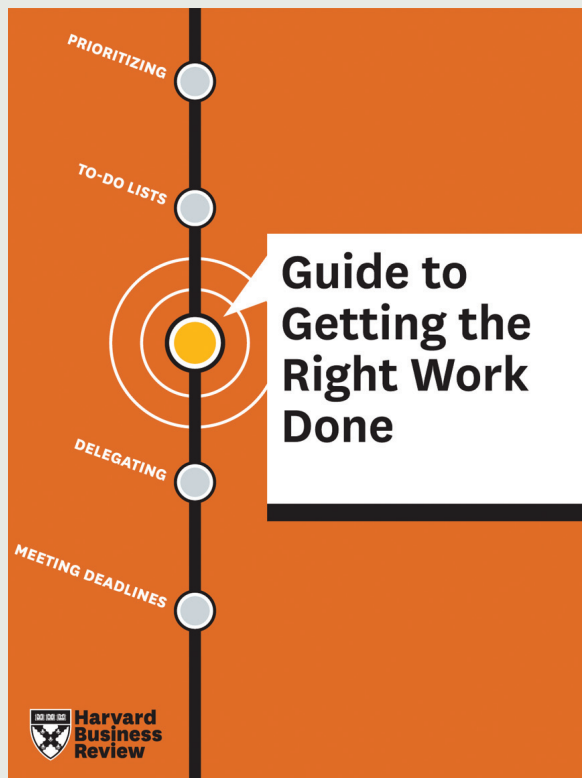
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